



THE BRAND-FUNDED DOCUMENTARY SYSTEM

MODULE 4

The 12-Slide Sponsor Deck

Practical funding strategy for independent and documentary filmmakers

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You have a target list and a reason for each brand. Now you need the document you send when a conversation warrants it: the sponsor deck. This is not your festival deck. It is not your investor deck. It is a **marketing proposal wearing a film's clothes**, written in the brand's language, ordered for the brand's brain.

Get one idea before anything else: **different buyer, different deck**. The deck that impresses a film financier, your bio, your festival strategy, your ROI (return on investment) (Return on Investment) model, will bore or confuse a brand marketer. Never send your festival or investor deck to a brand. Build this one. It ships as **Template C** inside the system; this module walks you through it slide by slide.

The order is the strategy

The deck moves in one deliberate arc:

Their World → The Film → The Audience → The Assets → The Ask.

You open in *their* world, not yours. You earn the right to talk about your film by first proving you understand their business. Only after the film, the audience, and the assets are established do you make the ask. A brand marketer reading this feels like they're reading a proposal built for them, because they are.

Two hard rules before the slides:

- **Never open with your bio.** Your credibility slide comes near the end, third person, as reassurance, not as the hook.
- **12 slides, hard cap.** Discipline is the message. A tight deck signals a producer who respects the reader's time.

Slide by slide

1 Cover. Film title + one still + "A partnership opportunity for [Brand]." Their logo is **not** on the cover, putting it there is presumptuous. **Their name only.**

2 Their world. "What [Brand] stands for," three bullets in *their own published language*, lifted from their mission page or latest campaign. This proves you did the homework and sets the whole tone.

3 The problem they share. The audience or values gap the brand publicly cares about, told as a story, not a stat. You're naming a need they already feel.

4 The film. Logline + three stills + status (in production, delivery [date]). One sentence on the access you have that no one else does.

5 The audience. Who watches, sized honestly, the niche plus how you'll reach them: festivals, community screenings, partner orgs, streamer target. **No guess work.** Analyze and cite your data source. If it's AI, cite that it's AI, but often AI will cite where they found it, so go directly to that article or link and confirm they got it right. A real niche lands; an inflated total addressable market gets you caught.

6 Why this film proves their values. Map two of the Four Assets to the brand, one line each. This is your Module 2 positioning, now aimed at this specific brand.

7 The activation inventory. Premieres, tour screenings, cutdowns, employee events, panel content. **Pictures beat words here**, show them what a program looks like.

8 Partnership tiers. Title / Presenting / Supporting, each with four to six concrete deliverables from the menu (Template E). Show the tiers but **price only the one you're proposing**.

9 The team. Two or three credibility line, awards, distributors. Third-person, faceless-friendly. This is where your bio lives, small and late.

10 Editorial note. State it plainly: "*Sponsors receive association and access, never editorial control, which is exactly why audiences trust the result.*" Trust is the product. Say it proudly.

11 Timeline & the ask. Production and delivery dates, the specific tier, the number, the payment schedule. One clear ask.

12 Contact. One email, one calendar link. Nothing else. Don't clutter the exit.

Design notes: film stills as full-bleed backgrounds, brand-neutral typography, 12 slides hard cap, PDF export under 10MB so it opens on a phone.

Building it step by step

Step 1 , Harvest their language. Before you touch a slide, read the brand's mission page and latest campaign. Copy their exact phrasing for Slides 2 and 3. You want them to recognize their own words.

Filmmaker to filmmaker: I have adopted AI wholeheartedly. I love it, I find it fascinating and beyond helpful. This is not the case for all filmmakers and I respect that. In preparing decks, I use AI for the look and content of my slides. Gamma and Claude Design are my current go-to's, and I continually research new models to market to keep up. You don't have to do this, but for my work, it's faster, design forward and works with me on implementing data and incorporating suggestions that work for each brand I approach.

Step 2 , Drop in your Module 2 positioning. Slides 5 and 6 are your audience and your two lead assets, already done. You're transferring, not inventing.

Step 3 , Pull deliverables from the menu. Slide 8's tiers come straight from Template E. Don't freelance the deliverables; the menu exists so your offer is consistent and priceable.

Step 4 , Hold the number for Slide 11. Everything before the ask builds the value. Don't leak the price early; let the deck earn it.

Step 5 , Cut to 12. If you're at 15 slides, you haven't finished. Cut. The cap is a feature.

Filmmaker to Filmmaker: I change each deck I use to suit the brand or sponsor. The body of the deck remains the same, statistics and data points, but the approach I align to each recipient. That's not to say if you write a more generic deck and send it to everyone it won't work, it might. I've had higher returns on my outreach by tailoring each deck.

The example thread continues

Dana (fictional; illustrative) builds a deck for the regional health plan she's targeting.

- **Cover:** film title, a still of a nurse on a night drive, "A partnership opportunity for [Regional Health Plan]." Their logo stays off it.
- **Their world:** three bullets in the plan's own words about member-first care and rural commitment, pulled from their site.

- **The problem they share:** rural communities losing access to care, the gap the plan publicly worries about, told through one nurse's story, not a statistic.
- **The film, the audience:** logline, three stills, delivery date; her honestly sized niche of rural nurses and communities, reached via festivals, community screenings, and partner nursing orgs. No guessing. Actual data.
- **Why it proves their values:** her two lead assets, audience access and values proof, mapped in one line each to this plan.
- **Activation inventory:** a named regional premiere, six cutdowns, two employee screenings with Q&A, shown in pictures.
- **Tiers:** Title / Presenting / Supporting from the menu; she prices only Presenting, the tier she's proposing.
- **Team, editorial note, timeline & ask, contact:** credibility third person and late; the trust line stated proudly; one tier, one number, one payment schedule; one email and one calendar link.

Twelve slides. Under 10MB. Built for this buyer, not recycled from her investor deck.

Common mistakes

- **Sending the festival or investor deck.** Wrong buyer, wrong language. Build this one. Adapt to each recipient if you have the time and creative capacity.
- **Opening with your bio.** The hook is their world, not your résumé.
- **Their logo on the cover.** Presumptuous. Name only until they've said yes.
- **Fantasy TAM (total addressable market) on the audience slide.** Inflated reach numbers get caught and cost you the room. Size the niche honestly.
- **Pricing every tier.** Show three, price the one you're proposing. Pricing all three invites them to shop down.
- **Blowing the 12-slide cap.** A bloated deck signals a producer who can't prioritize. Cut.
- **Burying or omitting the editorial note.** It's a selling point, not fine print. Slide 10, stated with pride.

- **A cluttered contact slide.** One email, one link. Make the next step obvious.

Action checklist

- ☐ Confirmed you are building a *new* deck, not reusing the festival or investor one.
- ☐ Harvested the brand's own language from their mission page and latest campaign for Slides 2–3.
- ☐ Built all 12 slides in order: Their World → The Film → The Audience → The Assets → The Ask.
- ☐ Kept their logo off the cover; put your bio third person on Slide 9.
- ☐ Sized the audience honestly on Slide 5 , no guess work.
- ☐ Mapped your two lead assets on Slide 6; pulled tier deliverables from Template E on Slide 8.
- ☐ Priced only the tier you're proposing; held the number for Slide 11.
- ☐ Stated the editorial note proudly on Slide 10.
- ☐ Kept it to 12 slides, film stills full-bleed, PDF under 10MB.

With a deck built for the buyer, you're ready to open the conversation. Go to Module 5.